



PARTNER (HITCH)

Will Smith in the Hollywood flick and Salman Khan in the Indian version help arrange dates for men. Both the films have comedy arising out of the hero coming in contact with a man looking to woo a rich heiress.



BHEJA FRY (LE DÎNER DE CONS)

Rajat Kapoor has fun at the expense of a dumb person every week till he bumps into Vinay Pathak. The 'original' French film has Thierry Lhermitte in a similar situation with Jacques Villette.

Indian filmmakers don't think they've hijacked anyone's ideas. "I don't think any film in India is plagiarised," says Bhatt, adding that by the time the film reaches the Indian audience, it becomes culturally different. If the essence of a film is different, it cannot be termed a copy, he says. So, although Mallika Sherawat and Lane may have both started off being unfaithful on a rainy night and the action in *Collateral* and *The Killer* may have started with a man crashing on the windscreen, according to Bhatt, these aren't copies. Director Vikram Bhatt's ready-to-be-released *Speed* is also said to be a clone of the fast-paced *Cellular*. The director isn't pleased with people calling his film



SEEMS LIKE OLD TIMES

AWAARAPAN (A BITTERSWEET LIFE)

A sharpshooter for an underworld don discovers that the woman his boss is seeing loves another man. Instead of killing her, he lets her go.

NAQAAB (DOT THE I)

The girl is going to marry a rich guy. Trouble begins when she meets another guy who sparks a passion that had been sleeping within her.

THE TRAIN (DERAILED)

A man, fed up of his married life, meets a girl on a train. What follows is an adulterous rendezvous.

a remake. "People adapt Shakespeare's plays into a film and are absolved of plagiarism," says Vikram, adding that his film has a political angle.

Even as producers continue to release 'inspired' films, buying rights legitimately has become easier. Yet, there have been a few instances where a production house has purchased the rights to an international film. It isn't that our filmmakers are not aware of such rights. After all, Priyadarshan bought the remake rights of *Thevar Magan* to convert it into *Viraasat*. More recently, Farhan Akhtar bought the rights to *Don* and Subhash Ghai was paid an astronomical price for the remake rights of his *Karz*.

Producers say Indian films don't have the kind of budget that can include buying rights of foreign films. A few have tried in the past but backed down after hearing the rates. "Earlier, Indian filmmakers didn't have access to international companies. But the trend is changing now," says Prithvi Nandy, whose company purchased the rights of two Chinese films—*Election* and *Dog Bite Dog*. Similarly, Ravi Chopra has bought the rights to the Marisa Tomei-starrer *My Cousin Vinny*. The entry of international entertainment houses like Sony Pictures and Walt Disney in the Indian film industry might change things.

While the mantra earlier was to wait for a Hollywood film to become successful and then convert it in its desi avatar, directors are now looking at obscure foreign films. Cloning a Korean, French or Chinese DVD saves two things—the cost of buying the rights and also the embarrassment of being called a copycat. But sooner or later, it is out in the open—*Bheja Fry* was a frame-by-frame lift of the French film, *Le Dîner de Cons* (*A Dinner Game*). The borrowing game has gone so out of control that a well-known DVD library in suburban Mumbai had to stop mentioning the names of its patrons on the lending cards because seeing the names of their peers often became a great source of amusement to filmmakers. The question is, will borrowed content keep the Indian audience amused? ■